1. Introduction

1.1 The Role of Mechanised Verge Maintenance

Road verges are cut because they are infrastructure. Vegetation left to grow closes sight lines at junctions and bends, obscures signs and barriers, blocks the drainage channels that keep water off the carriageway, and encroaches on the running surface itself. A national road network carries tens of thousands of kilometres of verge, and each kilometre is cut several times in a growing season, so the work is continuous, repetitive and performed almost entirely by machine.

It is also performed from a moving vehicle. Stopping to cut each section would require closing the lane, so a carrier drives the road at a few kilometres per hour while a boom-mounted mowing head works the verge alongside it. The head must hold a cut height of a few centimetres over ground that rises and falls continuously, follow a grass line that curves with the road, and do so without striking the surface hard enough to damage the tool or lift the machine.

The demands on the manipulator follow from that. The machine studied here, shown in Figure 1.1, carries a heavy rotating tool at the end of a long boom, works in intermittent contact with the ground, and must place that tool accurately while its own base is in motion. Hydraulic actuation is the standard answer at this scale: it supplies the force density and the tolerance to shock loading that electric drives do not, and it does so with components rugged enough for continuous outdoor operation. Precision, however, is not what hydraulics are good at, and that tension is the subject of this thesis.

1.2 Advances in Learning-Based Control for Hydraulic Manipulators

Two developments have changed what is achievable on machines of this kind.

The first is that policy optimisation in simulation has become practical for contact-rich manipulation. GPU-parallel physics engines run thousands of environments simultaneously which makes reinforcement learning feasible on tasks that would take years of real-machine